sonder

PRODUCT CASE · NEW APP · INDIA

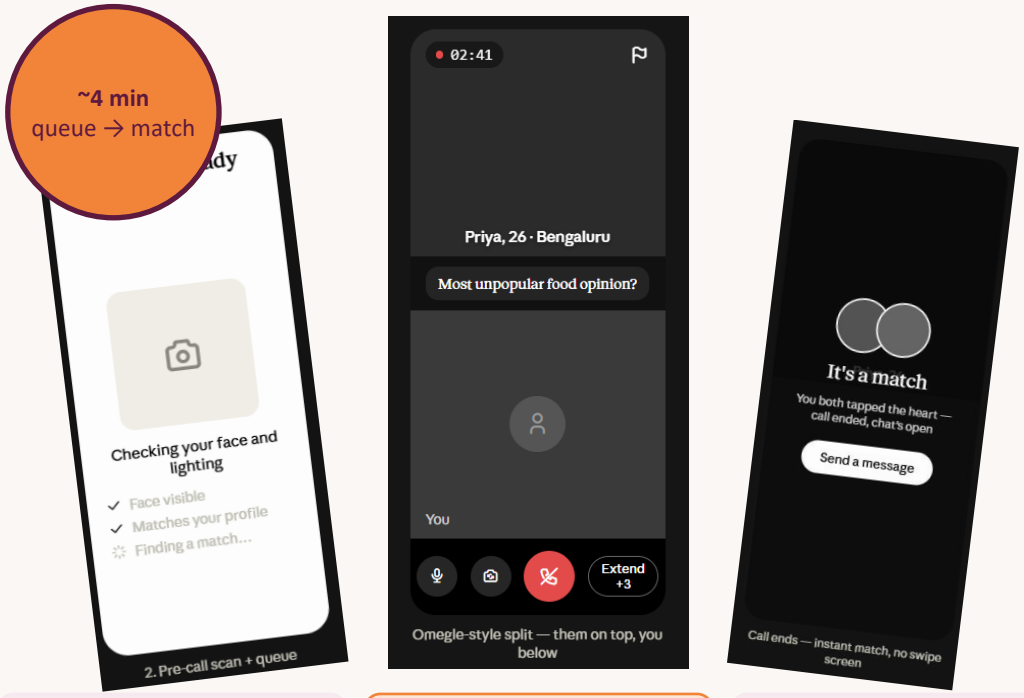
What if you could hear the vibe before a week of texting?

A **verified, live-first** dating app for urban India. Hear a real person for **3 minutes**, then both decide.

THE CASE IN 6 ANSWERS

1	**Problem**	Daters don't lack matches, they **can't trust** them: 75% see fakes, 2 in 3 never meet.
2	**Users**	**She can't trust, he can't get heard.** 37% already video-call first, on WhatsApp.
3	**Gap**	Incumbents call **after the match** because the swipe feed pays. Hinge dropped calls; Omegle died of safety.
4	**Solution**	**Verify → queue → 3-min voice call → mutual ♥.** No swiping, no video in v1.
5	**GTM**	**One city, one hour** first: Bengaluru Live Hours, 9–11 PM, women-first invites.
6	**Risks & Metrics**	North Star: **mutual hearts per weekly caller**. Pivot if hearts < 10% of calls after 8 weeks.

[Your name] · [College] · October 2026



1 **Verify** ID + live selfie → 2 **Call** 3 min, voice-first → 3 **Match** both tap ♥ → chat

At a glance

- **75%** see **fake or AI** dating profiles → so: verify **before** anyone talks — *McAfee India 2026*
- **2/3** have **never met** a match in person → so: a real signal by **minute 1** — *Juleo × YouGov 2024*
- **37%** **video-call** before a first date → so: give the habit a **safe home** — *Tinder report 2024*
- **₹2.8L** avg loss for the **1 in 7** scammed → so: **safety is the product** — *McAfee India 2026*
- **36%** report **dating-app burnout** → so: fewer, **better** conversations — *happn 2023 · n=2,700*

82M	33M	12M	40K
daters	metro	call-open	Yr-1

Sizing · Estimate · see Gap slide

Sourced cited · **Estimate** Fermi · **Draft** my call · **Persona** illustrative

PROBLEM

Indian daters don't lack matches; they can't trust them, so the first real signal arrives days too late

Ghosting and dead chats are the visible tip; underneath, fakes force days of text screening that can't carry chemistry

5 Whys · Iceberg

Why chats die · 5 Whys

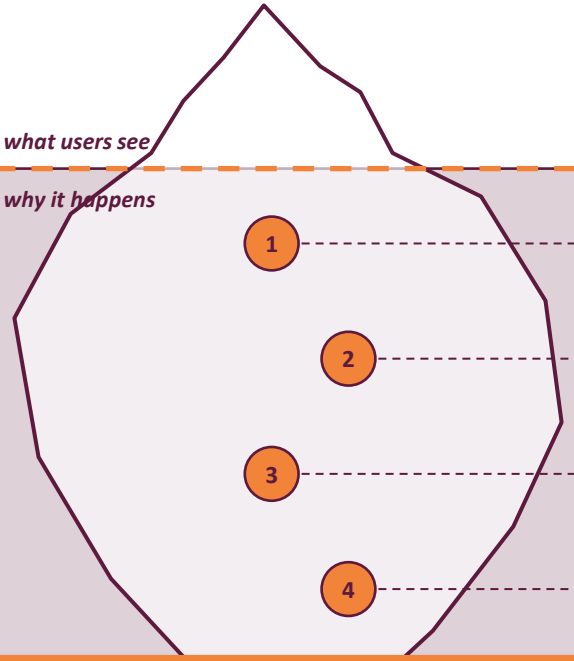
SYMPTOMS EVERYONE COMPLAINS ABOUT

- Ghosting
- Fake matches
- Dead chats
- Burnout · 36%

36%: happn 2023, Indian Gen Z & millennials

▲ *what users see*

▼ *why it happens*



WHY 1 · Can't trust the profile
75% have seen fake or AI-looking profiles

WHY 2 · So people text to screen
~5 hrs a week lost per dud match · Est.

WHY 3 · Text can't carry chemistry
no tone, humour or timing in 6 messages

WHY 4 · Chats stall before anyone meets
2 in 3 app users have never met a match

Day 5

ROOT CAUSE · WHY 5
The first **trustworthy signal** arrives after ~5 days of texting.

→ **Minute 1**
Sonder target

What fakes cost users

- **46%** talked to a **bot or fake**
- **33%** were **catfished**
- **1 in 7** **lost money**, avg ₹2.8L

McAfee India, Feb 2026

> *Every match these days is a full risk. I'll text someone for a week and they turn out totally different from their profile.*
>
> **Harsh, 22, Goa** — Persona

Women carry more risk

78% of Indian women have **met fake profiles**
Juleo × YouGov 2024

57% use **deliberate protective tactics**
QuackQuack · company data

What is "real chemistry"?

- **Tone**: warm or scripted
- **Humour**: laugh at the same things
- **Timing**: reaction speed, pauses
- **Realness**: voice fits the profile

Why now: AI makes fakes cheap



26% met an **AI bot**

46% found a **bot or fake**

→ Profiles get **easier to fake** every year; a live, verified call doesn't.

McAfee India · question wording differs between years

SO WE

Move a **verified voice** to minute 1 of discovery: a 3-minute call **before** the match, not a week of text after it.

- Verify first
- 3-min call
- Mutual ♥

Sources: McAfee India Modern Love 2024 & Feb 2026 · Juleo × YouGov Indian Matchmaking 2024 · happn India 2023 (via India Today) · QuackQuack women's survey · Day 5 and ~5 hrs/wk are Fermi estimates

USERS

Two metro daters fail for opposite reasons: she can't trust, he can't get heard

One mechanism fixes both: a verified voice before the match. 37% already do this, but outside the apps

CIRCLES · Identify

Two daters, opposite failures

Personas · illustrative

AN — Ananya, 26

Marketing manager · Bengaluru

"I screen every profile for days. By the time I trust someone, the chat is dead."

Context	New to the city; dating cautiously after a bad experience
Pain	Can't tell if a profile is real; **on guard** with every match
Need	Confirm someone is real **before** investing a week
Sonder	Verified-only queue; a 3-min call she can **end anytime**

Fails because she can't trust

VS

RO — Rohan, 27

Investment banker · Mumbai

"I send plenty of openers and rarely get a reply. It feels like shouting into a void."

Context	Out of a long relationship; swipes on his commute
Pain	**Rarely gets a reply**, even after a match
Need	Show personality beyond **6 photos and an opener**
Sonder	A guaranteed conversation; his humour **heard**, not skimmed

Fails because he can't get heard

Who we target · segmentation

Metro dating-app users, 21–32

- **Chatting well**: served today
- **Casual browsers**: not our user
- **Matched, chats fizzle**: ≈45%
  - **Women**: safety-first, hesitant to meet strangers → **Ananya**
  - **Men**: low reply rate, chats die fast → **Rohan**

→ Target = the fizzled middle. They already want to date; text is what fails them.

Shares: original deck's estimate; validate with a pilot cohort

Which pain first? · draft

Severity → \ Frequency →	
Scams, harassment	**Fake profiles · chats die · no replies** ← start here
Awkward first dates	Swipe fatigue, generic openers

What they do today

37% of Indian singles **video-call before** a first date

- …but on **WhatsApp**: no verification, no exit button, phone number already shared.
- Safety is their **#1 priority** before a first date.

We're not inventing a behaviour; we're giving it a verified home.

The supply constraint

~26% of Indian online daters are **women** (Woo, 2018; dated)

So the design favours women:

- **Women-first** invite waves
- **Priority queue**: women wait less
- Women set the **call filters**

Rohan's "no replies" is a **supply symptom**, not a profile problem.

Jobs to be done

AN — *When a match looks promising, help me **confirm they're real** before I invest a week.*

RO — *When I match, help me **be heard** before my profile gets judged.*

Shared job: get a **trustworthy signal in minutes**, not after a week of texting.

Sources: Tinder Modern Dating Report 2024 (India) · Woo urban India survey 2018 · Segment shares and pain ratings are draft judgements · Ananya, Rohan and Harsh are personas

GAP

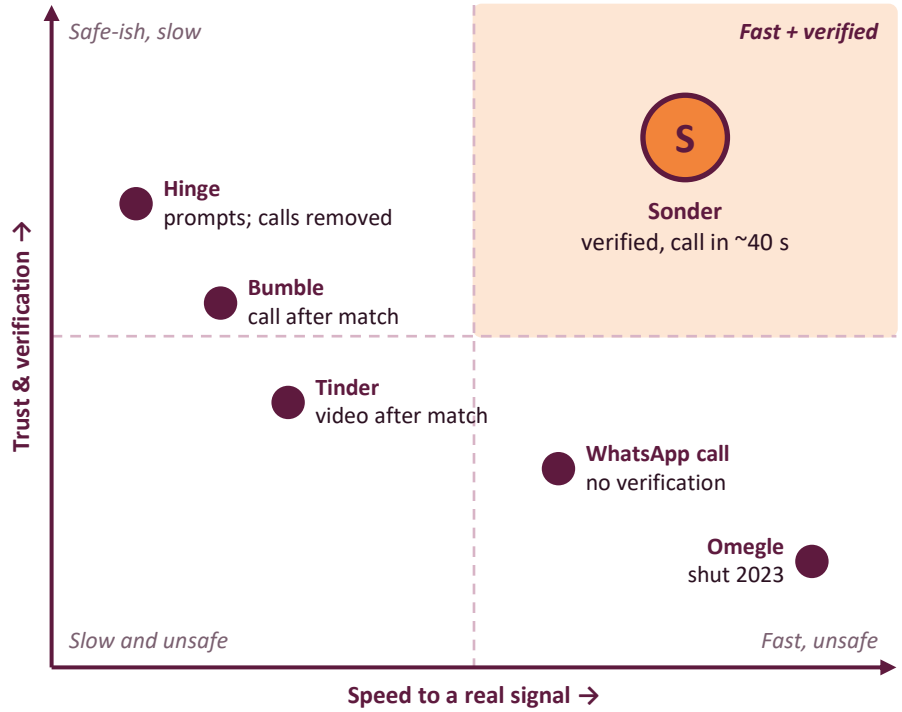
Every incumbent gates calling after the match, because the swipe feed is what they sell

Hinge removed calling, Tinder and Bumble keep it behind the match, Omegle had no safety: fast + verified is empty

Positioning 2×2

Where everyone sits

Positions: draft



App	Calling today	When it unlocks	The gap Sonder fills
Tinder	Face to Face video (India, 2020)	After a match, both opt in	No signal **before** you invest in a match
Bumble	Voice & video chat	After a match	Calling still comes after the texting grind
Hinge	**Removed** voice & video calls	Never; Voice Notes only	Walked away from live calling entirely
Omegle	Random video chat	Instantly, no match	**Shut down 2023**; zero verification
WhatsApp	Video call (37% of daters)	After swapping numbers	No verification, no exit, **number exposed**

WHY INCUMBENTS WON'T COPY IT · INNOVATOR'S DILEMMA

- Their revenue is the **swipe feed**: boosts, "see who liked you", **Hinge+ ₹1,199 / HingeX ₹1,499** a month.
- A call-first model **shrinks time in the feed**, which is the thing they monetise.
- So **Hinge removed calling** and Tinder keeps it behind the match.
- → A new app can build around the call; an incumbent would **cannibalise itself**.

What went wrong elsewhere: Omegle

Shut down in 2023 after years of misuse. **It died of safety, not of the format.**

- **Verify** before the first call
- **Mutual opt-in**: never random pairing
- **One-tap report**; call metadata kept for review

How big is the prize? · Estimate

82M	33M	12M	4M → 40K
Indian online daters (2023)	× 40% in top-8 metros	× 37% already call first	BLR + BOM; Yr-1 = 1%

82M: secondary study (use with care) · 40% and BLR+BOM share: assumptions

Evidence: voice already wins

1.4× more likely to **go on a date** with a voice prompt on your profile

Hinge exec via GMA · global

+47% likes on **prompts** lead to dates more than likes on photos

Hinge, 2024 data · global

The moat, once it works

- **Verified graph**: every user ID-checked
- **City liquidity**: dense Live Hours are slow to copy
- **Call data**: hearts and completions train matching

Sources: Hinge Help Center · afaqs (Tinder Face to Face, India 2020) · Match Group Q2 2026 10-Q · Fortune India via GDI (Hinge pricing) · Hinge press 2025 · GMA (Hinge voice prompts) · Estimates: Fermi chains, inputs visible

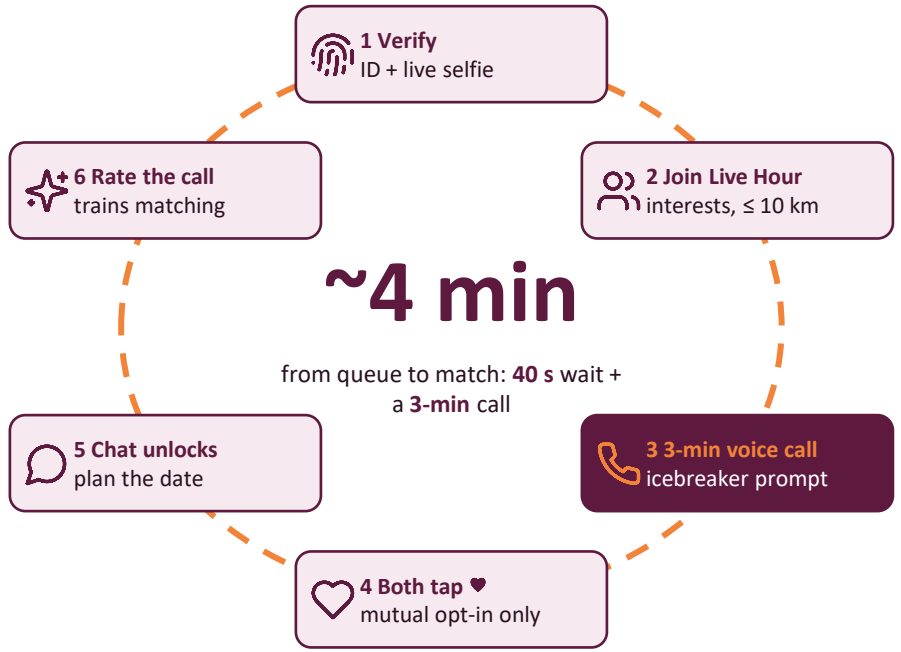
SOLUTION

Hear them for 3 minutes, verified, then both decide: discovery happens on a call, not a swipe

Voice-first, time-boxed, verified-only, mutual opt-in: each rule removes one reason chats die today

MoSCoW

The core loop



Design principle	Why	What it rules out
Voice-first v1	Lowers call anxiety; **tone carries chemistry**	Video in v1 (post-MVP, opt-in toggle)
3-minute hard stop	Easy to say yes, **easy to leave**	Open-ended calls, awkward exits
Verified-only	Trust **is** the core problem	Anonymous calls, unverified browsing
Mutual opt-in	Nobody is matched against their will	One-sided likes, a swipe queue

MVP scope · MoSCoW (draft)

Must: ID + selfie check · Live Hour queue · 3-min voice call · mutual ♥ → chat · in-call report

Should: Icebreaker prompts · +3 min extend (both tap) · women's priority queue

Could: Video toggle · post-call notes · city Live Hour events

Won't (v1): A swipe feed · unverified users · browsing profiles without a call

TRADE-OFF: VOICE OVER VIDEO

We give up: faces, a richer first impression.

We gain: lower anxiety, no appearance pressure, light on Indian mobile data, fewer abuse vectors.

Revisit when: completion > 60% and users ask for video.

Who's in the system

Callers
verified users who opt into Live Hours

Matching engine
queues and pairs by interests, distance, preference

Safety layer
ID check, pre-call AI scan, in-call report

Platform
identity, RTC calling, payments, notifications

How Sonder earns · freemium (draft ₹)

Free ₹0	Plus ₹499/mo	Priority ₹799/mo
3 calls / Live Hour mutual ♥ chat	unlimited calls +3 min, rematch	priority queue see who ♥ you

*Below Hinge+ ₹1,199: we sell **a call in minutes**, not more likes.*

Year-1 revenue · Estimate

40K verified callers
× 8% pay
× ₹499 × 12

≈ ₹1.9 Cr ARR

Sources: Fortune India via GDI (Hinge+ ₹1,199 / HingeX ₹1,499) · Pricing, MoSCoW split and revenue inputs are drafts; adjust · ~4 min = 40 s target wait + 3-min call

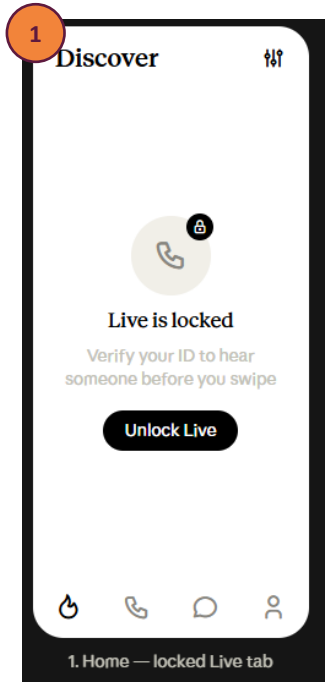
MVP

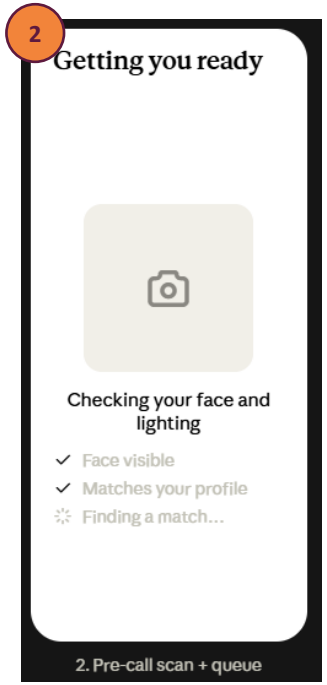
Five screens from curiosity to match, and not one swipe

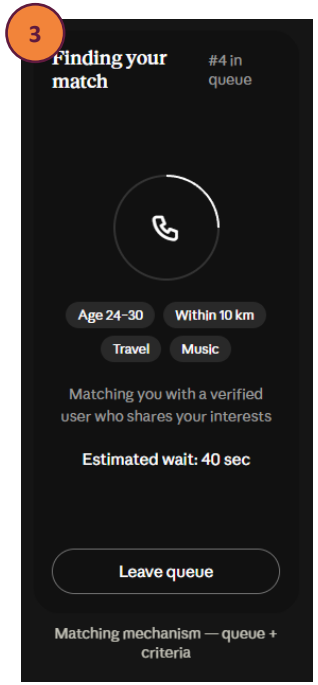
Each screen removes one reason to bail: a curiosity hook, trust before talk, a visible wait, a low-stakes call, an instant match

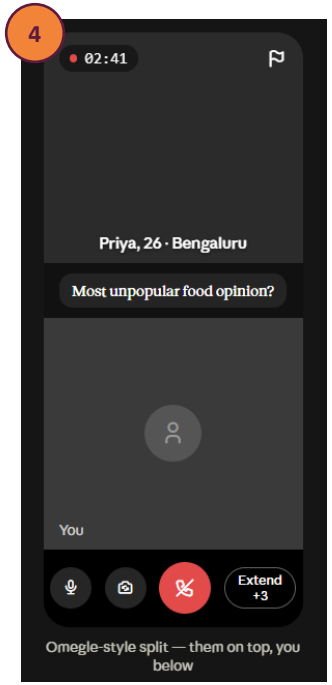
User flow

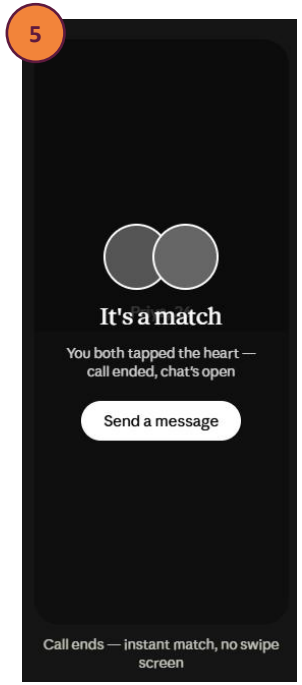
1 Locked Live tab → 2 Pre-call check → 3 Queue → 4 3-min call → 5 Match











live_tab_view | verify_pass | queue_wait_s | call_completed | mutual_heart

Logged event →

Feature	MVP	Later
Voice call, 3 min	✓	
Video toggle		✓
+3 min extend	✓	
Customer support chat	✓	
Subscription: cancel	✓	
Subscription: pause, skip		✓
City Live Hour events		✓

Edge cases we designed for

No match in 90 s
offer the next Live Hour slot

Hang-up < 30 s
no penalty, re-queue, no ♥ asked

Abuse mid-call
one-tap end + report; metadata kept

One-sided ♥
nothing shown; no rejection signal

1 Lock = curiosity
A lock badge creates FOMO before the tab opens; one-line CTA, no explainer.

2 Trust before talk
Face and lighting check runs quietly; the checklist builds trust before the call.

3 Make the wait fair
Shared-interest chips and "#4 in queue · ~40 s" keep people waiting.

4 Keep stakes low
Timer, prompt and report flag always visible; +3 min only if both tap.

5 No swipe screen
Both tapped ♥ → chat opens at once; one-sided hearts stay invisible.

Clickable prototype

Link: **[add prototype link]**
Screens shown are the actual prototype.

Screens: Sonder prototype · Event names and edge-case rules are draft specs · MVP / later split follows the MoSCoW on the previous slide

GTM

Win one city at one hour before scaling: liquidity is local, so launch is too

Bengaluru Live Hours 9–11 PM with women-first invites; every phase opens only when its gate is met

Beachhead

3 phases, each opened by a gate

Phase 1 M0–3 · Bengaluru, Live Hours only → **Phase 2** M4–6 · Mumbai + daily Live Hours → **Phase 3** M7–12 · Top-8 metros

Goal: Prove liquidity in one city

- Live Hours **9–11 PM, Thu–Sun**
- **Women-first** invite waves
- Campus + tech-park seeding
- Everything **free**

GATE TO NEXT

2,000

verified · ≥ 40% women · median wait < 40 s

Main risk: Weekday queues run thin → stay Thu–Sun until wait < 40 s

Goal: Prove the playbook travels

- Copy the Bengaluru playbook
- Launch **Plus ₹499**
- **Referral** priority passes
- Café Live Hour nights

GATE TO NEXT

15%

mutual-heart rate · W4 retention ≥ 25%

Main risk: Playbook doesn't transfer → BLR launch team on the ground 4 weeks

Goal: Scale on referrals, not ads

- Delhi NCR, Hyderabad, Pune, Chennai…
- Launch **Priority ₹799**
- All-day Live in mature cities
- Creator "blind call" series

GATE TO NEXT

40K

verified callers · ≥ 8% paying

Main risk: Quality dilutes at scale → keep verify + call-rating gates

Liquidity math · Estimate

≥ 300	callers live at once per city
1 in 10	compatible (age, interests, ≤ 10 km) → ~30 candidates each → wait < 40 s
15%	of verified users join a given Live Hour
= 2,000	verified users to open a city

Why Thu–Sun, 9–11 PM: packs a week's demand into 8 hours, so 2,000 users feel like a crowd.

Channels · where the first 2,000 come from

Channel	Why it fits	Cost	KPI
Campus ambassadors	21–25s, dense networks, social proof	Low	verified sign-ups
Tech-park communities	Where Ananya and Rohan work	Low	invites redeemed
Creator "blind call" reels	Shows the format in 30 s	Med	installs per reel
Referral priority pass	Each verified invite = priority queue	Low	k-factor

WHAT WE WON'T DO

- **No paid performance ads before the gate**: an install that lands in an empty queue is a lost user and a bad review.
- **No national launch**: liquidity is per city, per hour.
- **No skipping verification**, even if sign-ups drop.
- **No paid tiers before the gate**: pricing waits for liquidity.

Positioning

For **urban Indians 21–32** tired of fake profiles, Sonder is the app where you **hear a verified person before you match**. Unlike Tinder or Bumble, the call comes first.

Gates, targets, channel costs and liquidity inputs are draft estimates; adjust · Bengaluru first: tech-park density, matches the Ananya persona · India is Hinge's #3 market by MAU (Fortune India via GDI)

METRICS

Liquidity and safety decide whether Sonder survives, so they are measured first

North Star counts value for both people, not time in app, which is the metric incumbents optimise

North Star · AARRR

North Star metric tree

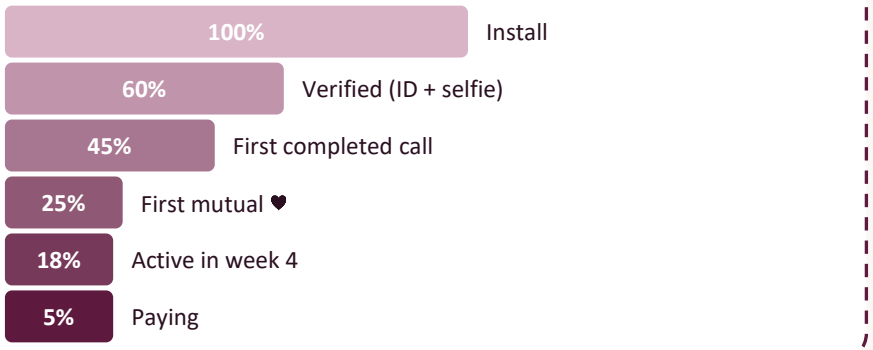
Targets: draft

≈1.4 Mutual hearts per weekly active caller
counts value delivered to both people

6	×	60%	×	40%
calls / caller / week liquidity: wait < 40 s		call completion calls reaching 3 min		mutual-heart rate per completed call

*We deliberately **don't** optimise session time: a fast match that leaves the app is a win.*

AARRR funnel · % of installs (draft)



Risk	Severity	Mitigation	We watch
Cold start: empty queue	**High**	One city, Live Hours 9–11 PM, **2,000-verified** launch gate	Median wait
Gender imbalance (~26% women)	**High**	Women-first invites, **priority queue**, women set filters	Women's wait, M:F
Safety incident on a call	**High**	**3 layers**: ID + selfie verify · pre-call AI scan · one-tap end & report	Reports / 1K calls
Call anxiety limits adoption	**Medium**	Voice-only v1, **3-min hard stop**, icebreaker prompt	Completion rate
Deepfake voice or face	**Medium**	Liveness check at verify; re-verify on any flag	Flags / 1K calls
Privacy (DPDP Act 2023)	**Medium**	**No call recording**; consented, time-boxed metadata only	Data requests

Guardrails · never trade these away

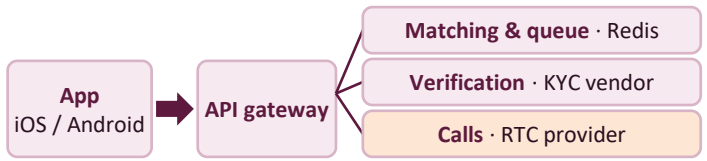
Women's median wait	< 40 s
Reports per 1,000 calls	< 5
Call completion	> 60%
Share of users verified	100%

KILL OR PIVOT IF, AFTER 8 WEEKS IN BENGALURU:

- Mutual-heart rate **< 10%** of completed calls
- Week-4 retention **< 15%**
- Women's median wait **> 2 min** despite invites

→ Pivot to **scheduled speed-call events**, not an always-on app.

Can it be built? · system sketch



Shared: payments · notifications · safety review queue

Second-order effects

- **New users:** women who quit apps over fakes may come back
- **Copycats:** incumbents may re-add pre-match calls; our moat is verified liquidity, not the feature
- **Offline:** faster first dates → café and event partners

All targets, thresholds and kill criteria are draft; set them after the Bengaluru pilot · DPDP = India's Digital Personal Data Protection Act, 2023 · Woo 2018 for the ~26% women figure